



intelligence was poor, and Britain's use of radar enabled the Royal Air Force (RAF) to track incoming planes and take off in time to meet an attack. The Battle of Britain in the summer of 1940 was the first real check on Hitler's progress, but Britain alone could not fight a power that now had control of almost the entire continent.

The world at war

What started as a European war gradually became a world war. In June 1940, Italy, emboldened by German successes, declared war on Britain and France, fulfilling the terms of the Axis agreement made between Hitler and Mussolini on May 22, 1939. But Italy's failures in Greece and North Africa forced Hitler to send German armies into these areas, as well as Yugoslavia.

On September 7, 1940 Germany began its first major air raid on London. The Blitz, as the bombing of the English capital became known, thrust civilians into the war and put relentless pressure on industry, ports, and British morale. With men joining the army, women were required to work in factories and on farms. Food rationing was introduced in Britain in January 1940, and people were urged to grow their own food. Nazi-occupied Europe also experienced food shortages, which weighed most heavily on the conquered populations.

Collaboration or exile

In some locations, the Germans worked with existing governments and fully supported puppet administrations, such as the pro-Nazi Vidkun Quisling in Norway and the Vichy regime in southern France. Led by Marshal Philippe Pétain, Vichy was officially neutral, but it collaborated closely with Germany, fighting the French resistance, and implementing anti-Semitic legislation.

Germany had total control in Poland and eventual control of the Baltic states. Monarchs and politicians of more than a dozen occupied countries escaped to Britain. Polish ministers set up headquarters in London, and Belgium's government operations were transferred there. The Dutch royal family, under Queen Wilhelmina, also sought refuge in London. When France fell to Germany, Charles de Gaulle, who opposed the newly installed Vichy government, became the voice of French opposition to the Nazi occupation.

In 1940 the biggest threat facing Britain was from German U-boats. As an island, Britain was dependent on its merchant ships to bring in vital supplies but also to export equipment to its fighting forces abroad, and German U-boats were sinking dozens of Allied ships each »